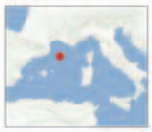
WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS

LAS HORMIGAS



Date September 4, 1285
Forces Aragonese: 40 galleys; French: 30 galleys
Losses Aragonese: unknown; French: 13 galleys captured

Location
Off Catalonia, Spain

In 1285 Philip III of France invaded the kingdom of Aragon, a rapacious enterprise declared a crusade by a partisan pope. French troops advanced down the coast of Catalonia, supported by a force of Provencal and Genoese galleys. Roger di Lauria's fleet sailed from Sicily to help resist the invasion.

Arriving in Barcelona at the end of August, di Lauria led his own 40 galleys from Sicily and 10 Catalan galleys north toward Gerona, which was under siege. At the same time, unaware of di Lauria's arrival, the French fleet advanced south toward Barcelona, hoping to annihilate the small Catalan galley force. The two fleets met, to their mutual surprise, some time before daybreak on September 4. Chroniclers disagree about almost every detail of the battle that followed. In the darkness the action must have developed into a confused close-quarters mêlée, with boarding the only effective tactic.

A lucky dozen of the outnumbered French galleys escaped back to Aigues-Mortes. The rest fell into the hands of a vengeful enemy. The wounded were tied to cables behind galleys and left to drown. Fit prisoners were blinded and sent back to the French king, led by one of their number left with a single eye. The invasion failed.

WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS

THE COUNTS



Date June 23, 1287
Forces Aragonese: 44 galleys; Angevins: c.70 galleys
Losses Aragonese: unknown; Angevins: 40 galleys captured

Location
Bay of Naples, Italy

By 1287 the original contenders for the throne of Sicily had disappeared from the scene. Charles of Anjou died in 1285, leaving southern Italy to his son Charles of Salerno, still a prisoner of the Aragonese after his defeat at the battle of the Gulf of Naples. In 1286 Peter III of Aragon also died. He left his Aragonese kingdom to his eldest son Alfonso III, but Sicily to his second son James II. In the absence of the imprisoned Charles II, the Angevin cause was led by Count Robert II of Artois. He assembled substantial land and naval forces in Naples for an invasion of Sicily, hoping to prevent James II's succession.

The Aragonese defense of the island still lay primarily in the hands of Roger di Lauria and his experienced fleet. In the spring of 1287 he sailed to relieve Augusta in eastern Sicily, which had been seized by Angevin troops, leaving the west of the island vulnerable to invasion. But the Angevins failed to act and di Lauria had time to sail back around the south of Sicily to seek battle with their fleet. In June he found them in harbor at Naples.



Catalan astrolabe
Many of the Catalans' naval skills were inherited from Spain's Muslims, as was the use of the astrolabe as an astronomical aid. This one is from the late 13th century.

The Count of Artois was willing to send his galleys out to fight. He had a far more substantial galley force than the one defeated by di Lauria off Naples three years before. There was also an impressive array of military leaders at his side, including Reynald III Quarrel, Count of Avella; Hugh, Count of Brienne, who was ruler of the Principality of Taranto; and Guy de Montfort, Count of Nola, son of ruled England. But these counts, for whom the battle is named, were no match for di Lauria in a sea fight. Far superior at maneuver, his experienced and highly motivated Sicilian galley crews attacked their opponents from the beam, destroying their oars and leaving them immobilized, to be massacred by the Catalan crossbowmen and boarding parties of fierce Spanish light troops, the *almogavers*.

More than half the Angevin galleys were captured, along with some 5,000 crew and soldiers. Those taken prisoner included Hugh of Brienne, and Guy de Montfort, who did not survive his captivity. The planned invasion of Sicily was abandoned, enabling James II to confirm his hold on the throne.

c.1245–1305

ROGER DI LAURIA

ADMIRAL OF THE ARAGONESE FLEET



Roger di Lauria was born into the nobility of Calabria, southern Italy, but was driven into exile at the court of Peter III of Aragon when the Angevins seized his family's lands in 1266. He proved his worth as a soldier before his appointment as admiral at the start of the War of the Sicilian Vespers in 1282. His energy and administrative skill were demonstrated in strengthening the Aragonese fleet, but he is respected above all for his leadership in combat. He never lost a single sea battle, showing a cunning, good judgement, and boldness that have earned him a reputation as the finest of medieval naval commanders. Ruthless toward his enemies, he remained unswervingly loyal to the Aragonese throne.

WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS

CAPE ORLANDO



Date July 4, 1299
Forces Aragonese and Angevins: 56 galleys; Sicilians: 48 galleys
Losses Aragonese and Angevins: unknown: Sicilians: 36 galleys captured

Location
Off northern Sicily

In the 1290s the struggle for Sicily took on a radically altered shape. James II inherited the throne of Aragon, leaving Sicily to his brother Frederick. But James then made an alliance with his old enemy, Charles II of Anjou, and led an expedition to regain Sicily for the Angevins. Roger di Lauria stayed loyal to Aragon and found himself fighting against his old Sicilian fleet, now led by Frederick and admiral Conrad d'Oria.

In summer 1299 King James and di Lauria sailed from Naples for northern Sicily, the war galleys escorting a convoy of troop transports. Frederick sailed from Messina to intercept, but moved too slowly. James was able to land his troops and horses at Cape Orlando.

When the Sicilians arrived, an onshore breeze made it hard for di Lauria to leave the bay where he was moored. Instead he adopted a tight defensive formation, his galleys drawn up in line close to the shore and linked by cables.

Frederick entered the bay on the morning of July 4, also placing his fleet in a cable-linked line. The galleys exchanged missiles at distance until a Sicilian captain, tiring of the punishment his crew was taking from the Catalan crossbowmen, cut his cables and plunged forward to engage the enemy at close quarters. Others followed suit and the battle became a mêlée. In the heat and exhaustion of combat Frederick, in the center of the Sicilian line, fainted and was rowed from the battle. Di Lauria got some of his galleys behind the Sicilians, who were gradually ground down in fierce fighting. Only 12 Sicilian galleys escaped. As at Las Hormigas, di Lauria was savage in victory, slaughtering the crews of captured galleys out of hand.



Prisoners of war
Angevin prisoners are escorted onto a Sicilian galley. Sicilian soldiers and sailors captured by di Lauria were not so lucky—they were often executed on the spot.

WAR OF THE SICILIAN VESPERS

PONZA



Date June 14, 1300
Forces Aragonese and Angevins: 59 galleys; Sicilians 32 galleys
Losses Aragonese and Angevins: 1 galley captured; Sicilians: c.20 galleys captured

Location Gulf of Gaeta, north of Naples, Italy

Despite his crushing victory at Cape Orlando, James II failed to seize Sicily for the Angevins from his brother Frederick. The following year a rebuilt Sicilian fleet boldly entered the Bay of Naples, challenging Roger di Lauria's Angevin galleys to come out and fight. Di Lauria prudently chose to wait for reinforcements from Genoa and Apulia before accepting the challenge. The one-sided engagement took place off the island of Ponza. The Sicilians' admiral Conrad d'Oria bravely attacked di Lauria's flagship, but despite inflicting some damage, was obliged to surrender, along with more than half his force. Frederick nonetheless retained Sicily in the peace treaty signed two years later.